

The Good News

Elevation of the Holy Cross Orthodox Church, Sacramento

Through the Cross... *Rector's Reflection*

As we approach Holy Week, we're given the opportunity once again to journey with our Lord and His disciples through these momentous events. Because for us, these are not just important things that happened long ago and far away. Rather, we remember them as the most-significant events in human history, and as events that still have the greatest relevance for us here and now. In order to fully live the Resurrection, we have to journey with Jesus to the Cross. For, as we'll soon sing, *it is through the Cross that joy has come into all the world*. We begin by journeying with Jesus and His disciples to Bethany. We witness Jesus greatest miracle: His raising of Lazarus who had been dead four days, manifesting His power over life and death. Crowds, hearing of this great miracle, rush out to meet Him as the Messiah on Palm Sunday, while the Jewish leaders, out of fear for their positions and what the Roman authorities might do, seek a way to put Jesus to death. We often identify with the children crying out Hosanna in the Highest, and think that if we'd been there, we would never betray Jesus, never leave His side. The Apostles themselves thought the same, and yet all but one would forsake Him and flee. (cont'd)



Use Permit Approved!

On January 12th, our development plans were brought before the Sacramento Planning Commission at long last...after over three years of hard work and countless studies and reviews. And, glory be to God, the Planning Commission **unanimously approved our Use Permit** ! With this in hand, our team has now begun preparing construction documents for the first phase of site work, and is soliciting cost estimates for all phases of site work and construction. We are also exploring options for financing. As Sunday attendance now averages around 150 people, we feel the need all the more acutely to move forward. And we trust that the Lord, who continues to bring people to His Holy Church, will provide the means to see the project through, so long as we faithfully do our part. With that in mind, we need to keep our fundraising strong to stay on track, and have set a **goal of raising at least \$35,000 during the Lenten Season**. Please consider a donation toward the building up of our parish!



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Lenten Retreat & Special Guests

On Sunday March 29th, we had a special visit from Mother Macrina and Sister Marie of Holy Assumption Monastery. Following the Divine Liturgy, the nuns joined our Middle and Teen Church school classes, discussing their journey to monasticism, St. Mary of Egypt, and preparations for Palm Sunday and Holy Week. The classes were well-attended and well-received by our youth! A little later, Mother Macrina offered an inspiring presentation on The Theotokos as the Gate of Heaven. She highlighted some of the remarkable hymnography of the Triodion about the Mother of God, from whom our Lord Jesus Christ received His flesh and His human nature, and she reflected on the Theotokos's quiet but faithful presence throughout the events of Holy Week. She likewise highlighted the Holy Virgin's intercessory role in the lives of many saints like St. Mary of Egypt in bringing them to her Son, just as she continues to play an important intercessory role in all of our lives. Mother Macrina's talk concluded with an engaging Q&A and discussion. We're grateful to the sisters for their visit, and to Abbess Melania for giving them the blessing to be with us!



Reflection cont'd: If we journey to the Cross with the proper understanding, we discover that we too have at times been fickle, at one moment shouting Hosanna and resolving to endure to the end, and at another moment, forgetting our Lord, in some way denying him through our actions, perhaps preferring money (like Judas) or a comfortable status quo (like the chief priests and scribes) over what Jesus is calling us to. Nevertheless, as St. Paul remarkably exclaims: *If we are faithless, He remains faithful; He cannot deny Himself* (2 Tim 2:13). Our Lord endures everything for us out of love and a desire for our salvation. →

Holy Week & Bright Week Schedule

Sat. 4/4 Lazarus Saturday, 9AM
Vigil of Palm Sunday, 6:00 PM
Sun. 4/5 Palm Sunday Divine Liturgy, 9AM
Mon. 4/6 Bridegroom Matins, 9AM
Bridegroom Matins, 6PM
Tue. 4/7 Bridegroom Matins, 6PM
Wed. 4/8 Matins of Holy Thursday, 6PM
Thu. 4/9 Vespers Divine Liturgy of Holy Thursday, 9AM
Matins of Great & Holy Friday, 6PM
Fri. 4/10 Royal Hours, 9AM
Vespers of Holy Friday (Burial Service), 3PM
Matins of Great & Holy Saturday, 6PM
Sat. 4/11 Vespers Divine Liturgy of Holy Saturday, 9AM
Paschal Vigil (Nocturns, Matins & Divine Liturgy), 11PM followed by picnic-style fellowship
Sun. 4/12 Paschal Vespers, 1:30PM followed by potluck and Egg Hunt
Wed. 4/15 Vespers of Bright Thursday, 6PM
Thu. 4/16 Bright Thursday Divine Liturgy, 9AM

...He doesn't want us to perish in our sins, neither in this life nor eternally in the age to come! Jesus takes our sins upon Himself so that He can release us from their power. He dies on our behalf in order to raise us up with Himself, to live and reign with Him, now and in the age to come. *For if we died with Him, we shall also live with Him. If we endure, we shall also reign with Him.* Journeying to the Cross spiritually brings us to a place of deep repentance and self-awareness. It is because of my sins too that the only-sinless One journeys this path of rejection, mocking, cruelty and torture so I might come to my senses and live: *Father, forgive them, for they know not what they do*, He prays. And once we come to this awareness, and weep before the tomb on Great and Holy Saturday, we are ready for the RESURRECTION that only the Son of God can accomplish. For our path to heaven is not apart from the Cross, but through the Cross: in taking up my Cross and following Him, crucifying what is fallen and selfish within me to make a place for His Light and Grace and Joy. So that we too may say, *I have been crucified with Christ; it is no longer I who live, but Christ lives in me*, and if Christ is in me, what greater joy could I possibly have?